

FROM NOMADISM TO MONARCHY?

Revisiting the Early Iron Age Southern Levant

Edited by
Ido Koch
Oded Lipschits
Omer Sergi

MOSAICS 3



From Nomadism *to* Monarchy?



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Collapse and Regeneration in Late Second Millennium Southwest Canaan

Ido Koch

Introduction

During the 20th century, the final two centuries of the second millennium BCE were generally viewed in scholarly circles as a transitional period in the Southern Levant, which saw the region transform “from a province of the Egyptian empire... into a national Israelite state” (Singer 1994: 282). Academic inquiry into this period in southwest Canaan has focused on the collapse of the centuries-long Egyptian empire, Philistine settlement and hegemonic consolidation, along with their struggle against the Israelites that ultimately concluded with David’s victory.

Within this discourse, decades of scholarship have crystallized Egyptian sources, biblical narratives and material remains into an overarching paradigm: First, the conventional chronology for the appearance of the Israelites in the highlands was anchored in the late 13th century BCE based on the reference to Israel on the Merneptah Stele (see summary and literature in Hasel 2008), which was linked with the biblical conquest-and-settlement narrative, data regarding the destruction of the last Late Bronze towns and the appearance of rural

settlements across the highlands. Second, Egyptian sources describing Ramesses III’s battles (early 12th century BCE) against invading “Sea Peoples,” the Philistines included, were projected onto additional Late Bronze Age destructions and the appearance of locally produced Aegean-style pottery in order to argue that a violent Philistine invasion had taken place (Macalister 1914). Following stories from the Books of Judges and Samuel, a heroic historical narrative was surmised: The Philistines intent on conquering the entire land were confronted by the Israelite tribes, who banded together and crowned themselves a king. Both the Israelites and the Philistines were credited with their own “material culture”—a set of pottery forms, architectural concepts, dietary practices and cult objects that distinguished each from the other (Dothan 1982; 1998; Dever 1993; 1995). Consequently, Iron I destructions were associated with one or the other of these two parties, and the spread of specific material traits thought to have been associated with each culture were interpreted as reflecting its territorial expansion (Singer 1994: 315–326).

The Israelite narrative was reshaped considerably during the 1980s with the integration of European-led

biblical criticism and anthropology-oriented theories (e.g., Lemche 1985). In this regard, credit must be given to the archaeology-based studies presented in the original *From Nomadism to Monarchy* volume (Finkelstein and Na'aman 1994) for altering the prevailing academic mindset regarding society in the highlands during the Iron I. Since then, nuanced studies of the material remains from the highlands have led to meticulous discussions and fierce debates regarding the circumstances that precipitated the Iron I settlement wave, its chronology and its relationship to developments in the lowlands (Faust 2006; Finkelstein and Mazar 2007; Gadot 2017; Chapter 9; Finkelstein, Chapter 17). Scholars now discuss the place occupied by the Israelites among the several collective identities shared by the kin-based communities spread between the southern periphery of the Jezreel Valley and the northern portions of the Beersheba–Arad Valley. Questions have arisen regarding how this identity prevailed and by what process, a process which was undoubtedly nurtured by the kings based in Samaria and perhaps their peers in Jerusalem as well (Sergi, Chapter 10).

Long held perspectives regarding the Philistines have likewise been scrutinized. No longer should scholars view the Philistines as emerging from a specific location, at a specific moment or as constituting a homogeneous society in the lowlands south of the Yarkon (Maeir and Hitchcock 2017a; 2017b; Maeir, Chapter 11). The multivocality of the material remains is now emphasized, and theory-based analyses are now invoked in order to explain the various behavioral innovations that characterize this period (Hitchcock and Maeir 2013; Stockhammer 2013). Nowadays, Philistine archaeology focuses on local-newcomer interactions and employs fine-tuned frameworks for dealing with changes in domestic practices, technological innovations and evident continuity in multiple local traditions, along with transcultural discourses (e.g., Yasur-Landau 2011; 2012b; Maeir and Hitchcock 2011; Mazow 2014; Faust 2015; Hitchcock *et al.* 2015; Maeir, Davis and Hitchcock 2016).

A fundamental element of the Philistine paradigm is the interpretation of a specific scene in the long description of Ramesses III's battles against hostile incursions into Egypt (Breasted 1930: Pl. 37). There, the vivid description of a fierce battle that took place in the king's eighth year contains a scene of wagons carrying Sea People warriors

alongside women and children. This became the ultimate evidence of Philistine migration (although nowhere is this explicitly stated). At first scholars located the battle in the Northern Levant and suggested that the Philistines had been forcibly settled by Ramesses III in Egyptian strongholds in Canaan (Alt 1944). Stadelmann (1968) disputed this suggestion, proposing instead that the Egyptians fought the Philistines somewhere on the eastern outskirts of the Nile Delta, alongside the maritime battle depicted in another relief. It was further argued that the Philistines and their allies coordinated multiple attacks that shook the Egyptian empire (which ultimately led to its collapse), in the process settling along the coast of its Canaanite province in territory they had seized for themselves (Bietak 1993). However, this latter scenario is based on shaky grounds, as despite the explicit reference to Amurru in the Northern Levant, scholars were locating the land battle far to the south (Singer 1994: 292 n. 52), while conflating it with the maritime battle that had occurred three years earlier. Instead, the Egyptian sources describe a more complex scenario, in which Ramesses III confronted several attacks in *different* years. One attack was a sea raid during his fifth year, that likely occurred near one of the Nile's outlets, while the other was a land battle fought at Amurru during his eighth year (Ben-Dor Evian 2016).

Consequently, there is an absence of any reference to the Philistines being present in the Southern Levant prior to Adad-nirari III's mention of Philistia in his inscriptions dating to the late 9th or early 8th century BCE (Bagg 2007: 189–191). The biblical sources that have traditionally filled the lacuna between the Egyptian and the Neo-Assyrian sources, mostly stories about pre- and early-monarchic Israel, can be of no assistance either. The scholarship of the last decade has undermined the assumption that these stories contain authentic historical memories of pre-monarchic Israel while elaborating upon their complex literary development over time (see Chapters 14–16, this volume). The Philistines arrived in the Southern Levant sometime before the 9th century—and, as I will argue, probably before the 10th century—although the specific date cannot be narrowed down further with any certainty.

Consequently, the practice of labeling of Iron I material remains from the Southern Levant as “Philistine” is

somewhat dubious. However, this is not an entirely novel revelation. The view that invading Philistine warriors carried with them a technologically innovative urban culture has been called into question by numerous scholars since the 1970s, who have offered alternate explanations for the observable changes in the Iron I (Brug 1985; Bauer 1998; 2014; Drews 1998; Sherratt 1998; Sharon 2001). The two most common features uniting these alternate reconstructions are: 1) an emphasis on retrospective analysis of the preceding social structure in the region during the period of Egyptian dominance in an effort to understand the changes that occurred during the Iron Age I; and 2) limited credit given to the small numbers of newcomers who had integrated within the autochthonous population (or the complete dismissal of migration as a factor altogether). Interpretations differ regarding how the Philistines are best characterized, with some considering them to have been a warrior elite (like the Latin Europeans in the Levant during the Middle Ages), others viewing them as mercantile communities enmeshed within a pan-Mediterranean trade network, yet others postulating that they were local warriors who adopted a new collective identity.

I forward a similar retrospective analytical approach to the archaeological data herein. In a nutshell, the collapse of the Egyptian colonial network in Canaan after four centuries of development opened a space for the regeneration and reorientation of local societies, which took place at various scales, in a variety of scopes and along different trajectories throughout the region. Some ecological niches experienced moderate continuity in both social structure and practices, while others, which apparently underwent more severe turmoil, did not. Southwest Canaan—which had become Philistia by the 9th century BCE—was clearly within the latter group. Although, both the degree of continuity and the development observed in various practices that had originated in the preceding period suggest societal resilience and bring forth questions regarding the course by which local identity was reshaped. The possible role of the Philistines in this process is considered in the concluding remarks.

The Egyptian Colonial Network: An Outline

Multiple written sources of various genres from the 16th to the 12th centuries BCE and a rich material record

unearthed during dozens of excavations across the lowland south of the Yarkon provide ample evidence of the Egyptian colonial network (Morris 2005; Martin 2011; Koch 2021: 12–70). A process that began during the Late Bronze I with the revival of settlements that had been destroyed in the Middle Bronze III and the commencement of Egyptian presence along the coast (in the region of Gaza and later in Jaffa as well) generated intensive interaction between the local society and the Egyptian court and its agents (Koch 2021: 12–16). The royal language of military campaigns and forced capitulation was coupled with descriptions of a vivid colonial arena. The predominant source for such information available to modern scholars is the al-Amarna Correspondence (early to mid-14th century BCE) (Rainey 2015), which describes the interactions between the court and its agents on the one hand, and local rulers located at six or seven centers in the southwestern part of Canaan (Fig. 12.1) on the other: Maḥoz/Yavne-Yam, Gezer, Tel Beth-Shemesh (?), Gath/Tell eš-Šafi, Ashkelon, Lachish and Yurza/Tel Haror (Na'aman 2011; Finkelstein 2014; Koch 2016). Clearly, this is a snapshot of ca. 30 years rather than an all-encompassing picture of the political structure of southwest Canaan during the Late Bronze Age. Indeed, rulers from other centers might have starred in regional politics during preceding and succeeding generations.

The content of the letters discloses the active role played by the local elite in the expansion of Egyptian hegemony within Canaan: The local rulers repeatedly stressed their affinity to Egypt, their involvement in Egyptian social networks such as the court and the army and their devotion to the king of Egypt, usually in order to gain Egyptian protection during local conflicts (Na'aman 2000). And yet, Egyptian military intervention was rarely dispatched to their aid. The actions of these local rulers in Canaan might be interpreted as a surrender to Egyptian political hegemony, but they enjoyed some benefits from their relationship with the Egyptians—buttressing of their rule, expansion of their ties with other polities and participation within a broader economic sphere.

Accordingly, a meshwork of southwestern Canaanite and Egyptian colonial interactions developed and intensified as the years went by and the various parties became better acquainted; thus, an entangled colonial



Fig. 12.1: Southwest Canaan during the “Amarna Period” (base map prepared by Itamar Ben-Ezra)

society emerged. Means of control (hubs, garrisons, administration, client-patron relations) became increasingly complex and had more impact on the local landscape, while greater numbers of locals served the colonial system (though some opposed it) (Koch 2021: 25–44). Exposed to multiple nodes in the colonial

network, its various components gradually changed their practices—Egyptian iconography, already localized in the Middle Bronze II–III, now had a greater impact on the local repertoire (Schroer 2011), Egyptian deities were translated into local deities and vice versa (Cornelius 1994; 2004; Tazawa 2009; 2014; Koch 2017a), while

localized manifestations of elite Egyptian cuisine (Koch 2014), charm practices (Koch *et al.* 2017) and burial customs (Braunstein 2011) were all adopted. It should be pointed out that in such a setting, any distinction between the ethnonyms “Egyptian” and “Canaanite” would have become somewhat blurred.

The Egyptian colonial network in southwest Canaan reached its zenith during the Late Bronze IIB. Jaffa was fortified and fashioned with royal inscriptions (Burke *et al.* 2017: 98–99, 105–112, 126); Egyptian holdings expanded to include the hinterland of the existing centers, dotted with estates and production centers constructed at Tel Aphek to the east of Jaffa (Gadot 2010), at Tel Seraʿ (Martin 2011: 224–228) and Deir el-Balah (Dothan and Brandl 2010a; 2010b) near Gaza. A short-lived fortress at Ashkelon (Martin 2009) might have served the Egyptian army (probably following Merneptah’s campaign). Settlements such as Tel Ashdod (Dothan and Freedman 1967: 74–83; Dothan and Porath 1993: 39–49), Tell eṣ-Ṣafi (Maeir 2012a: 18, 224–229, 252, 258–259; Shai *et al.* 2011), Tel Azekah (Lipschits, Gadot and Oeming 2017: 11), Tel Lachish (Tufnell, Inge and Harding 1940; Tufnell 1958: 49, 51–61, 65–68; Ussishkin 2004: 188–201, 323–351, 1033–1045) and Tel Haror (Oren 1993; 1995) prospered, while the continuity of rural settlements and human activity in their hinterland suggests a certain stability (see summary in Koch 2017b: 183 with literature). Some of these prosperous settlements enjoyed development of their local economy, featuring modest signs of specialization. Examples of this include the herding of prime-age sheep for wool production at Lachish and the traction of the fields there by prime-age cattle (Croft 2004: 2270, 2283–2284).

At the same time, local resistance to Egyptian colonialism, already documented in the Amarna Correspondence and even earlier, led Seti I, Ramesses II and Merneptah of the Nineteenth Dynasty to conduct military campaigns against local towns and tribes (Morris 2005: 343). There is likely a connection between these years of turmoil and the destruction of many of the prosperous Late Bronze IIB settlements—including Jaffa

and its outpost at Aphek, Gezer, Tel Ashdod, Lachish, Tell Beit-Mirsim and Tel Haror—and the abandonment of others—such as Tell eṣ-Ṣafi. The agency in each event could have been the Egyptian army along with additional elements (compare the many violent episodes mentioned in the Amarna Correspondence), such as attacks by apiru bandits, shasu raiders, pirates along the coast and intraregional rivalry among competing local groups (Millek 2017).

The decades that followed this period of turmoil were characterized by Egyptian activity in the region of Gaza and in Jaffa, now a diminished local power with few substantial focal points, along with the continued appropriation of Egyptian practices by local society. The Egyptian holdings around Gaza were expanded (Koch, forthcoming), and the hub at Jaffa was restored. Glimpses of the colonial network during this period are gleaned from the information embedded in the dozens of hieratic inscriptions on bowl fragments found in the region of Gaza and in adjacent settlements, particularly Lachish.¹ These documents, which record the shipment and storage of large quantities of agricultural commodities, preserve indications of the role of local rulers and imperial officials of local descent in running this system, which supplied provisions to Egyptian hubs. Precious information about the Egyptian holdings in Canaan, perhaps even regarding Gaza itself, appears in Papyrus Harris I (9:1–3), which describes the acts of Ramesses III, including the establishment of a temple to Amun in Canaan, that some scholars believe was in Gaza (Uehlinger 1988; Wimmer 1990: 1086–1088; Morris 2005: 727–729), but this suggestion has been criticized (Higginbotham 2000: 58–59; Hasel 2009: 12–13).

Local power was probably held by the rulers of Lachish. The remains of the affluent settlement include temples and storage facilities that reflect the introduction of several Egyptian architectural concepts. One of these “entangled” buildings was a well-built temple located at the top of the mound, fashioned out of a mudbrick floor, color-plastered walls and pillars made of cedar of Lebanon (Ussishkin 2004: 215–281). The temple was looted before its

1. These inscriptions were found at Tel Seraʿ (Goldwasser 1984), Tel Haror (Goldwasser 1991), Tell el-Farʿah (S) (Goldwasser and Wimmer 1999), Deir el-Balah (Wimmer 2010), Tel Lachish (Sweeney 2004), Tell eṣ-Ṣafi (Wimmer 2012; Wimmer and Maeir 2007) and Qubur al-Walaydah (Wimmer and Lehmann 2014). A few hieratic inscriptions, including three from Tel Beth-Shean and one from Ashkelon, deal with subjects unrelated to the Egyptian administration (Wimmer 2008).

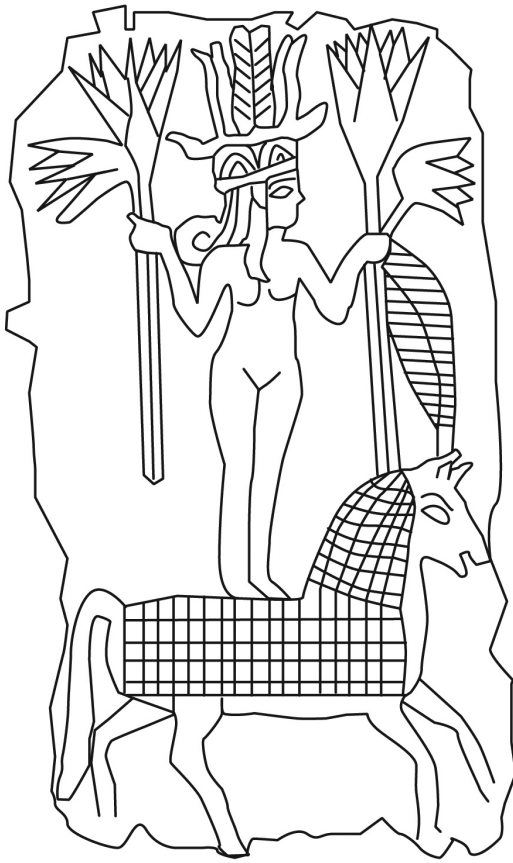


Fig. 12.2: Depiction of a golden foil from Lachish Level VI (after Clamer 2004: Fig. 21.21:4)

destruction so only a limited assemblage was recovered, including one delicate golden foil that preserves the image of a local deity (Fig. 12.2), exemplifying the interconnected nature of the colonial network in southwest Canaan. Several aspects of the figure exemplify entangled pictorial traditions: one is the nude goddess holding flowers, an image that originated in the Northern Levant, was localized in the Late Bronze Age in the Southern Levant and then later localized in Egypt; another is the iconography of Astarte and her horse, a Northern Levantine conception that was localized in Egypt then later transferred to the Southern Levant (Koch 2018: 30–32).

Unfortunately, this phase of prosperity was even shorter than the previous one. At some point the temple was looted before being destroyed, as was another temple, located in the northern part of the settlement, as well (Weissbein *et al.* 2016). An additional indication of unrest may be gleaned from a large building located southwest of the temple, which consisted of a long room with a roof supported by six pillars surrounded by a paved courtyard

that likely served some non-mundane function (Ussishkin 2004: 355). This large space had been modified at a later date when the floor was raised, the wall was repaired and cooking installations were constructed within. The relatively simple assemblage of utilitarian pottery vessels found in the destruction debris supports the possibility that the public space had been appropriated during a period of social instability, perhaps by refugees prior to the final destruction of the town (*ibid.*: 353, 355).

Several nodes of the Egyptian colonial network met a violent end, whereas other settlements were unaffected. The harbor at Jaffa was struck by a violent episode at least once before its destruction during the late 12th century BCE (Burke *et al.* 2017: 99–100, 113–117, 126–128). Single violent events during the second half of the 12th century BCE brought an end to the estate at Tel Sera' and to the prosperous town at Tel Azekah (Kleiman *et al.* 2019), where the inhabitants had been highly integrated into the Egyptian network (Koch *et al.* 2017). At the same time, life in many other settlements

continued as it had, apparently without interruption (Koch 2017b: 186–189, and see subsequent discussion).

The destructive episode which occurred in the second half of the 12th century BCE has been commonly associated with the collapse of the Egyptian colonial network or viewed as a consequence of the collapse (see Millek 2018 with literature). Diminishing numbers of objects from the Southern Levant bearing names of rulers later than Ramesses IV and the base of a statue from Tel Megiddo bearing the name of Ramesses VI are the only attestations of some sort of colonial activity during this period of instability. Written records are of little help since the Southern Levant disappears from Egyptian records following the reign of Ramesses IV. The information we have regarding the problems in the Egyptian court during the reigns of Ramesses III's sons and grandsons and the rise of provincial powers who eclipsed central authority (Snape 2012) suggest that the court was unable to maintain its colonial network.

The Iron I: Regeneration

The observed settlement pattern during the Iron I² represents the outcome of this second wave of destructions, marked by the emergence of two new political centers at the expense of the former Egyptian-oriented centers. To the north, Jaffa contains only meager remains from this period (Herzog 2008; Burke *et al.* 2017: 101–102), while a new harbor was established just a few kilometers further to the north, at Tel Qasile. Three development phases of Iron I occupation have been detected at this small site, which feature an expanding settlement with a temple, storage facilities and specialized workshops. The inhabitants of the settlement interacted with the northern Levantine littoral, Cyprus, and Egypt (Mazar 1980; 1985; 2009). Eastward along the Yarkon, all excavated sites, both those resettled and those newly founded, exhibit a marked rural character (Gadot 2006).

Further south, the rural landscape that emerged after the destruction and abandonment of former towns, that had existed during the Late Bronze Age IIB–III, was characterized by both continuity and gradual development. This includes Tel Batash Stratum V (Mazar 1997: 27–28, 76–81, 98–102, 177–180; Panitz-Cohen and Mazar 2006: 134–138), Tel Ashdod Strata XIII–XIA (Dothan 1971: 27–31, 136; Dothan and Porath 1993: 61–64, 70–79, 86–88, 92; Dothan and Ben-Shlomo 2005: 7, 13–37, 65–121, 132–161), Tel Beth-Shemesh Strata 6–4 (Bunimovitz and Lederman 2016: 173–187 and 677–694), Tel Gezer Strata XIII–XI (Dever, Lance and Wright 1970: 26–28; Dever *et al.* 1974: 53–61; Dever 1986: 60–124; Ortiz and Wolff 2017: 72–78), and the notable expansion of Tell eš-Šafi (Maeir 2012b: 352–354 and Table 1; and Maeir, personal communication). The greatest change was the establishment of a large, 20-hectare, settlement at Tel Migne, which became the chief settlement in the entirety southwest Canaan (Finkelstein 2007: 520–521; Yasur-Landau 2007: 615). Various public buildings, cultic activity, workshops with semi-industrial specialized production and a varied material assemblage all attest to social complexity (Meehl, Dothan and Gitin 2006; Dothan and Gitin 2008; Mazow 2014; Dothan, Garfinkel and Gitin 2016).

These changes in settlement patterns and power shifts, therefore, reflect a reconcentration of power at different centers than those that had flourished under Egyptian hegemony. These changes should be viewed against the backdrop of the previous social order's breakdown. The destruction of Jaffa provided an opportunity for the local population in the Yarkon Basin to change land tenure in the hinterland and to develop an alternative center, while the rise of a new group (or groups) at Tel Migne was facilitated by the demise of the region's previous elite. Thus, both cases represent developments brought about by the demise of the Egyptian-oriented elite, a process that led to the emergence of a new social structure unrelated to the previous centers of power.³

2. The Late Bronze–Iron Age transition was undoubtedly a gradual one, encompassing most of the Late Bronze III and, to a certain extent, the early Iron I. Distinct markers of the Iron I, such as the settlement of the highlands and local production of monochrome pottery, are nowadays treated in a more nuanced manner, as scholars have recognized that it has been processes and differing trajectories rather than single events that shaped each archaeological phenomenon. For the settlement pattern, see Chapter 9, this volume. For the pottery, see the discussion that follows.

3. Regrettably, nothing is known about the fate of Gaza, the most important Egyptian center in Canaan. The meager finds from the mound of Gaza, Tall il-Ḥarubeh/Kharrubi (Phythian-Adams 1923), point to the existence of a settlement of unknown size. For further discussion, see Koch (forthcoming).

Animal-Based Economy and Accumulation of Wealth

Like its predecessors, the newly founded society in southwest Canaan primarily relied on animal-based agriculture, including the raising of herds for wool production and the cultivation of fertile valleys and plains. However, the main transformation in the Southern Levant during the Iron I was growing specialization within local animal exploitation trends, (Lev-Tov, Porter and Routledge 2011; Sapir-Hen, Gadot and Finkelstein 2014: 736; Sapir-Hen, Meiri and Finkelstein 2015: 309–311), which suggests increasing societal complexity and an alteration of economic focal points.

Iron I animal exploitation trends point to continuity and further development of the practices that had been common during the Egyptian colonial period. From the Late Bronze Age II–III onward, equivalent

sheep:goat ratios indicate a general tendency toward non-specialized herding with different methods of exploitation suggested by the mortality rates (Sapir-Hen, Gadot and Finkelstein 2014: 714). The previously mentioned low level of lamb slaughter at Tel Lachish, suggests a concentration on wool production, whereas higher infant-slaughter levels at other sites suggest herding for meat supply (Horwitz 2009: 544; Lev-Tov 2010: 95). Another LB II–III trend was the growing reliance on cattle (Fig. 12.3), evident at Tel Lachish and a cluster of sites farther north, at Tel Ḥarasim (Horwitz 1996), Tel Batash (Panitz-Cohen and Mazar 2006: 311, Table 81) and Tel Miqne (Lev-Tov 2006; 2010), as well as in the estate at Tel Aphek (Horwitz 2009).

Moving to the Iron I, several trends are evident. A possible focus on prime-age herding at Tel Miqne (Lev-Tov 2010: 97–98) and to a lesser degree at Tel Aphek (Horwitz 2009: 544 and Table 21.5a) and Tell

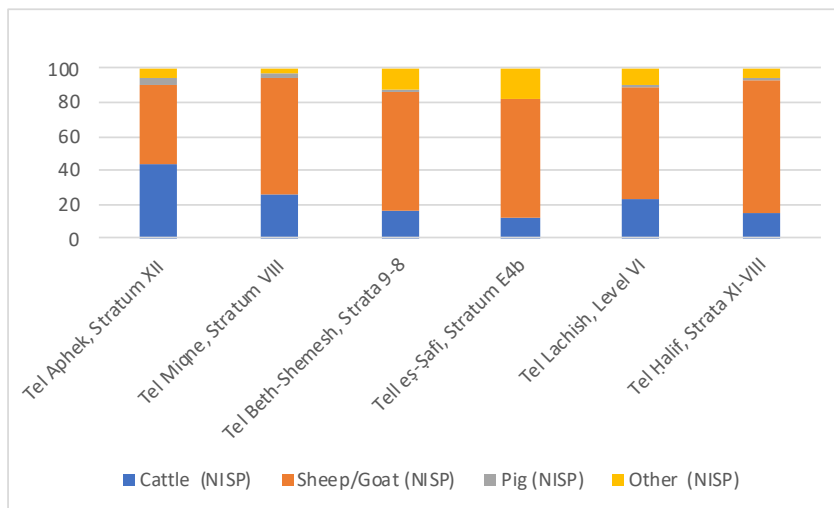


Fig. 12.3: Late Bronze IIB–III sheep/goat and cattle ratios in faunal assemblages from southwest Canaan

Site and Stratum	Cattle (NISP)	Sheep/Goat (NISP)	Pig (NISP)	Other (NISP)
Tel Aphek, Stratum XII	44	46	4	6
Tel Miqne, Stratum VIII	26.5	68	2	3.5
Tel Beth-Shemesh, Strata 9–8	17	69	1.5	12.5
Tell eṣ-Ṣafi, Stratum E4b	12	70	–	18
Tel Lachish, Level VI	23	66.5	0.7	9.3
Tel Ḥalif, Strata XI–VIII	15	78	2	5

eş-Şafi (Lev-Tov 2012: 594) may indicate a shift in preference for wool production, as was previously common at Tel Lachish. At the same time, several textile-production workshops located at Tel Miqne, Tel Ashdod and Ashkelon feature innovative production techniques shared by other Mediterranean communities, such as new types of loom weights (Rahmstorf 2005; 2011; Yasur-Landau 2009: 509–510) and a new means of wool processing (Mazow 2006–2007; 2013). One might suggest, following Sherratt's (1998: 306) preliminary observation, that textiles became a prime product in the region during this era.

Already prominent cattle exploitation was intensified at Tel Aphek, Tel Miqne and apparently Tel Batash (Panitz-Cohen and Mazar 2006: 311, Table 81), expanding during the later phases of the Iron I to Tel Ashdod and Tell eş-Şafi (Fig. 12.4). Pathological evidence for the use of cattle in traction at Tel Miqne (Lev-Tov 2006: 211–212;

2010: 96–97), Tell eş-Şafi (Lev-Tov 2012: 595–596) and Tel Ashdod (Maher 2005: 284) has given rise to scholarly reconstructions of intensified cultivation of surrounding fields (also Yasur-Landau 2010a: 297).

This overview suggests that during the Iron I there was an intensification of the already prominent land use at Tel Miqne and Tel Aphek and a focus on secondary products. The demise of the local elite might have led to a change in land rights, with a greater portion of ownership of fields and herds held by the newly emerged groups. Historically speaking, once the Egyptians had withdrawn there were no overlords to demand and consume local commodities. Taking all these factors into consideration, it may be surmised that the restructuring of local society and the development of continuing trends of animal exploitation (such as a growing reliance on cattle) led to the accumulation of great wealth by some groups, especially those located at Tel Miqne.

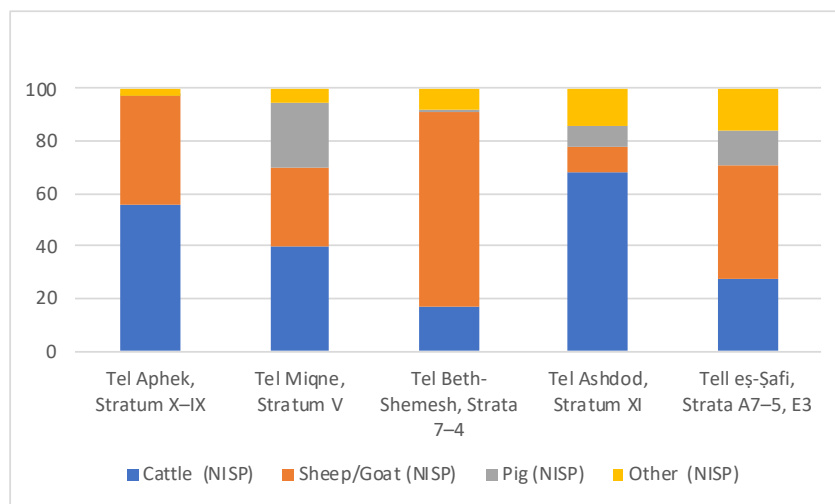


Fig. 12.4: Iron I sheep/goat and cattle ratios in faunal assemblages from southwest Canaan

Site and Stratum	Cattle (NISP)	Sheep/Goat (NISP)	Pig (NISP)	Other (NISP)
Tel Aphek, Stratum X-IX	56	41	0.03	2.93
Tel Miqne, Stratum V	40	30	24.5	5.5
Tel Beth-Shemesh, Strata 7-4	16.5	75	0.01	8.49
Tel Ashdod, Stratum XI	68	10	8	14
Tell eş-Şafi, Strata A7-5, E3	27.5	43	13.5	16

Changes in Religion

The potential for analyzing cult practices as a means of understanding societal changes has been demonstrated in multiple studies, and the benefits of understanding the colonial past remain valid in the postcolonial present. The most significant source of information about public cult during the Iron Age I is the temple precinct at Tel Qasile (Strata XII–X) (Mazar 1980; 1985; 2000).⁴ The three phases of the precinct had central structures whose holiest space was consistently located at their back; their walls were lined with benches, and were integrated with courtyards which included additional structures. Their ground plans changed considerably over the years and incorporated local traditions with features that are known from contemporaneous Cyprus and the Aegean (Mazar 1980: 68). The transformations in the ground plan of the temples were explained by Mazar (2000: 222) as follows: “The inhabitants of Tell Qasile lacked a definite concept of temple architecture. Innovation and the lack of a well-defined architectural tradition are perhaps the most noticeable characteristics of the sacred complex at Tell Qasile.” Another possible explanation is that the persistence of the three architectural elements—the location of the holy space, the benches used for votive placements and the courtyard hosting the rituals themselves—suggests that the flexibility in the ground plan of the temple reflects the ability of the inhabitants of Tel Qasile to appropriate architectural concepts while keeping the essence of their cult.

Continuity can also be seen in the paraphernalia of the Tel Qasile temples. Most of the many objects uncovered within the temple are associated with Canaanite traditions, or alternatively a site-specific version of that tradition (Mazar 1980: 119; 1985: 126). A particularly important object found at the foot of the altar of Stratum X is a clay plaque in the form of a temple façade with what remains of two nude, standing female figures, the hands apparently grasping their breasts (Mazar 1980: 82–84, Fig. 20). The plaque resembles shrine models from Canaan and the figures it bears may be associated with clay figurines

from the Late Bronze Age, which depict a female figure who appears to be grasping her breasts in identical fashion (Keel and Uehlinger 1998: 100–103). It seems therefore that the items from the temple at Tel Qasile reveal a cult dedicated to a goddess, whose image and cultic objects were associated with a local tradition that had developed during the Late Bronze Age.

Another aspect of continuity is visible in the ritual placement of building deposits (Koch 2021: 55–58, 98). The practice of lamp-and-bowl building deposits was a localization of an Egyptian tradition that spread among the communities living in and around the Egyptian administrative centers. This practice continued in southwest Canaan during the Iron I at Tel Gezer, Ashkelon, Tel Beth-Shemesh and Tel Miqne, and further into the Iron IIA at Tel Azekah. In addition, the integration of other types of vessels, already observed in the LB III, was expanded and closed vessels, such as juglets and pilgrim flasks, were now deposited at Ashkelon (Aja 2009: 383, Table 4.6) and Tel Qasile, although in the latter case, they were incorporated into a wall (Mazar 1980: 38).

An additional aspect of the local cult’s development over time involves the clay figurines. The figurines that depict the goddess grasping branches mostly disappeared during the Late Bronze III. In their place, two types of figurines became common which are also primarily known from southwest Canaan. One type is an Aegean-style figurine known as Psi-type—a standing figure with arms raised and small breasts in the form of circles—that first appeared in Late Helladic IIIB style during the Late Bronze IIB at Tel Ashdod, Tel Beth-Shemesh, and Tel Lachish (Leonard 1994: Nos. 2183, 2190, 2201, 2213, 2254; Hankey *et al.* 2004: Nos. 91–91). This type appeared again during the Iron I, reflecting the Late Helladic IIIC style, at which time it was probably locally produced, at Tel Miqne, Tel Ashdod, Ashkelon and Tel Qasile (Ben-Shlomo and Press 2009: 47–48; Ben-Shlomo 2010: 37–38; Press 2012: 145–160). This dialogue between local traditions and Aegean-style iconography resulted in the emergence of a new and unique type of

4. The large Building 350 in the lower mound of Tel Miqne Strata V–IV has been interpreted as a temple by the excavators (Dothan 2002). However, based on the ground plan and spatial analysis of the finds, others interpret the structure as an elite residence that might have hosted some sort of cultic activity (Mazow 2005: 295–301; Yasur-Landau 2010a: 308).

figurine, which depicted a seated female whose body is incorporated into her chair (Ben-Shlomo and Press 2009: 49–54; Russell 2009; Ben-Shlomo 2010: 45–51; Press 2012: 154–156, 160–165). Items of this type, commonly referred to as “Ashdoda,” have been found throughout southwest Canaan, including on the Coastal Plain, in the Yarkon Basin, the Shephelah and perhaps in Jerusalem as well (Ben-Shlomo and Press 2009: 53).

Consequently, it is clear that the standing figure was common mainly among the coastal inhabitants of southwest Canaan and may reflect their relations with Cyprus and the Aegean sphere, while the seated figure was more widely distributed and thus may have represented a cult that was accepted among significant portions of the local population. As in previous cases of the appearance of “foreign” motifs in local iconography, it is difficult to know whether the image was of a Mediterranean goddess who became accepted in southwest Canaan or perhaps a local goddess represented in a new way. This is another example of the entanglement of local and non-local cult traditions, which can be regarded as a long-term and recurring form of continuity, as non-local elements and new meanings were added to the images of local female deities, resulting in the transformation of the local goddess, or in some cases even replacement by a new goddess who had become popular among the local people. This instance of a newcomer goddess who had become fused with a local goddess may belong to a broader phenomenon reflected in similar occurrences along the coasts of the Mediterranean following encounters between Aegean goddesses and their local counterparts (Budin 2014).

Lastly, there was a marked change in the charm practices in the region during the Iron I (Koch 2017c). Glyptic assemblages of the period are characterized by a decline in the number of scarabs. Scarabs found in Iron I contexts are mostly restricted to a specific group, the “mass-produced early Iron Age series.” These scarabs were used for sealing (rather than as amulets only) and were widely consumed in the region of Gaza, in the Nile Delta and at several northern Canaanite sites (Münger 2003; 2005; Keel 2013b; Ben-Tor 2016; Ben-Dor Evian 2017). They were apparently quite rare in the inland regions of southwest Canaan, where New Kingdom scarabs had been the most popular amulet during the Late Bronze Age, appearing in

limited numbers during the late Iron I, before becoming more common during the Early Iron IIA.

Other types of amulets common in the Iron Age I were locally produced conoids and oval, button-like artifacts, mostly made of limestone and decorated with simple and schematic scenes. The images chosen for these charms attest to a focus on local pictorial traditions, which is best exemplified by the popularity of the horned animal, commonly attested in the region as early as the Chalcolithic period (Schroer and Keel 2005: 109–111, 114ff.). This image was popular in the Middle Bronze Age (Schroer 2008: 48 with literature, 194–203), becoming scarce in the Late Bronze Age, when it was mostly restricted to Mitanni-style cylinder seals and locally produced plaques. It became popular once again during the Iron Age I (Fig. 12.5), from when it has been found depicted on dozens of artifacts within a variety of scenes with floral motifs, scorpions, anthropomorphic figures and sucklings (Shuval 1990: 105–111; Keel and Uehlinger 1998: 125; Staubli 2009: 611–616; Ornan 2016: 293–297).

The main reason for the decline in the popularity of scarabs at sites in the Shephelah, the same region where large numbers of these artifacts had once been found, was obviously due to a weakening connection to Egypt itself. Yet, additional factors might have been at work here. As the Iron Age I amulets were also found in burials, no change in function can be observed; there was, however, a selective preference for non-Egyptian artifacts and non-Egyptian imagery. The attention given to locally manufactured limestone artifacts decorated with local imagery that had been “underground” during the days of Egyptian hegemony can thus be explained as reflecting a broader local tendency to modify practices associated with the previous system, at times even replacing them with a more pronounced local flavor.

Reorientation of Regional and Interregional Interaction

The changes that took place in the consumption of amulets in southwest Canaan throughout the second millennium BCE reflect broader processes of integration and disintegration in the region and the Nile Valley. Similarities in practices between these two regions grew



Fig. 12.5: Iron Age limestone conoids depicting horned animals: 1) Tel Miqne Stratum V (CSSL: Ekron No. 72); 2) Tel Beth-Shemesh Stratum III (CSSL: Beth-Shemesh No. 161); 3) Tell es-Şafi Area T (CSSL: Gath No. 56); 4) Tel Gezer, “Fourth Semitic Period” (CSSL: Gezer No. 44)

throughout the Middle Bronze Age, intensified during the Late Bronze Age, and declined during the Iron I. The archaeological remains convey the locals' orientation toward Egypt and their exposure to, and appropriation of, a wide range of Egyptian cultural features, including conceptualizations, vocabulary and daily practices. The local elite were exposed to a limited range of Egyptian practices from which they both actively and passively appropriated those that they perceived as deepening their connection to Egypt and raising their status among the locals, thus integrated aspects of Egyptian culture within their own social identity (Koch 2018: 32–33; 2021: 67–70).

Yet nothing lasts forever. The gradual disappearance of Egyptian officials and soldiers among others, and the collapse of the Egyptian-oriented system created a vacuum that was soon to be filled. With greater wealth in their hands than ever before, prominent groups in southwest Canaan during the Iron I were stronger than their predecessors and were able to reinforce their economic connections with other regions. For centuries, these interactions had been based on multifocal trade networks, contributing to transcultural discourses across regions; now these had survived, through reorientation and the collapse of the great polities (Sherratt 2003; Monroe 2009; Gates 2011; Broodbank 2013; Knapp and

Manning 2016). The most prominent player in the eastern Mediterranean during the 12th century BCE was Cyprus, where various communities maintained trade connections with coastal regions around the basin, consequently appropriating a varied range of artifacts and practices, from technology to cult (Hitchcock 2008; 2011; Voskos and Knapp 2008; Knapp 2012). As the southwestern Canaanites reoriented their attention more toward this Mediterranean network, they became increasingly influenced by it, exchanging concepts and technologies.

The development of a regional pottery style represents one such example of this reorientation. During the Late Bronze III, several workshops along the Levantine littoral and farther inland began producing local versions of a limited range of forms and decorations that reflect Cypriot mediation of more remote Aegean inspiration (Lehmann 2007; Mountjoy 2010; 2013; Rutter 2013; Sherratt 2013). Such workshops were located in northern Canaan (Yasur-Landau 2006; Cohen-Weinberger 2009; Zukerman 2009; Sherratt 2013: 650–651), where their products were few and had no influence on the local pottery tradition; conversely, two workshops in southwest Canaan, at Tel Ashdod (Sherratt 2006) and Tel Mique (Killebrew 1998; 2013), had products that were widely consumed by nearby communities, giving rise to the development of the so-called “Philistine Bichrome” style. This second generation of pottery production vividly reflects the bi-directional discourse of the era, embedding further “foreign” influences (Ben-Shlomo 2010; Ben-Dor Evian 2012) and thus attesting to interregional contacts alongside patterns of regional exchange of technologies, styles and concepts. These exchange patterns are evident in the spread of such production from Tel Mique and Tel Ashdod to workshops located at Tel Qasile (Yellin and Gunneweg 1985), in the region of Gaza (Ben-Shlomo and Van Beek 2014: 793), in the highlands of the al-Jib Plateau (Gunneweg *et al.* 1994) and at Megiddo (Martin 2017).

Interaction with other regions also generated sporadic movement of individuals and groups of skilled workers, sailors and merchants from varied backgrounds looking for new markets or seeking new opportunities (cf. Gates 2011: 388). The introduction of cooking vessels, Aegean-inspired clay figurines, and architectural styles are the aspects most commonly discussed in the literature as evidence that such newcomers were present

in southwest Canaan (Faust and Lev-Tov 2011; 2014; Yasur-Landau 2012b; Maeir, Hitchcock and Horwitz 2013)—although this inference is not without dispute (Middleton 2015). Less persuasive are conclusions regarding the origin(s) of settlers or their numbers in given communities on the basis of the distribution patterns of these innovations. Societal mechanisms as yet invisible in the archaeological record were most likely in operation during these dynamic years, leading to various interactions, appropriations and rejections between newcomers and the indigenous populations (Maeir and Hitchcock 2011: 58).

Indeed, most of the innovations of this period exhibit a gradual emergence at the various sites they appear, in a wide range of performances which were produced in a variety of shapes and sizes and used in diverse local contexts. They were never part of a monolithic culture, but rather an ongoing process shared by several communities, the most notable having been Tel Mique. These communities selectively adopted and adapted practices and concepts useful in the local context. With time, some of these innovations were further developed, integrating additional innovations from abroad with local discourse around specific concepts, producing a varied range of remains that are ultimately identified as characteristic of the Iron I in the region.

Conceptualizing Collapse and Regeneration in the Post-Egyptian Southern Levant

In summary, the collapse of the Egyptian colonial network led to the growth of a new social structure, situated around multiple centers but most prominently Tel Mique. Equipped with specialized economic means, the stronger groups at Tel Mique and neighboring communities were able to accumulate wealth and build connections with other regions. A variety of Cypriot, Anatolian, Aegean and North Levantine objects and practices appeared, some which became entangled with local traditions, possibly via mediation of newcomers. Contrary to the reconstruction widely accepted within the research literature, these settlers were a small number of migrants who ultimately assimilated into the local society. It appears that the rising elite, located at Tel Mique, integrated various cultural practices as part of a broader

process in which they sought new means to express their power and status.

Similar accounts of continuity and change characterize other narratives about the revived social complexity in the Southern Levant during the Iron I. The most famous case is that of Megiddo. The last Late Bronze occupation lasted a few decades following the collapse of the Egyptian colonial network before being destroyed (Finkelstein *et al.* 2017). It was soon rebuilt, attaining prosperity in the mid-11th century BCE. On the one hand, continuity is evident in the architectural layout, including the location of the palace, which scholars have interpreted as evidence of a social revival, in which the local population who had survived the turmoil were able rebuild complex society (see Arie, Chapter 7). Continuity was manifested in multiple aspects of life, including pottery production, building techniques and styles as well as ideology—the same cult places were in use employing paraphernalia in Late Bronze traditions while burial practices likewise remained the same. On the other hand, some changes did take place, including the distribution of economic means beyond the hands of the elite (such as metal production), and the appropriation of innovative ideas and practices (pictorial motifs, wall brackets and textile production techniques). These changes, in the words of Arie (Chapter 7), attest to the Iron I inhabitants of Megiddo's "propensity for absorbing and assimilating foreign influences."

In contrast to the situation at Megiddo, many centers that had flourished in the Egyptian colonial period were left in ruins or were resettled only to a limited extent, with no evidence of any accumulation of wealth. Such was the well-known case of Hazor, which had been utterly destroyed during the Late Bronze IIB with its local hegemony having been superseded by a new social structure centered around Tel Dan, Tel Abel Beth-Maacah and Tel Kinrot. The former two sites probably developed from preceding LB settlements, whereas the latter was settled sometime later (Kleiman, Chapter 6). In this regard, the prosperity of the well-planned urban center at Tel Kinrot—the only site in the Upper Jordan Valley to have provided substantial Iron I material evidence to date—is illuminating: it was heavily fortified, hosted insulae of well-built domestic units and specialized workshops and was populated by a hierarchical society. Moreover, its inhabitants were integrated in an

interregional network that brought migrants, artifacts and influences from the southern Levantine coast, the Northern Levant and Transjordan, which were entangled with local pottery production, architectural styles and mortuary practices (Münger 2013; 2017: 119–123, 128–129).

These, among other sociocultural phenomena in the Southern Levant during the late second millennium BCE, represent multiple variants of local responses to the collapse of the Egyptian colonial network. As is common following the disintegration of a prevailing social structure, this collapse led to multifaceted social regeneration, including a variety of reorientations and restructurings that opened the door for greater social mobility (Schwartz and Nichols 2006; McAnany and Yoffee 2009; Faulseit 2016; Middleton 2017). With the breakdown of social limitations, ambitious non-elite individuals were afforded greater opportunity to pursue power and to establish new focal points (Conlee 2006: 107–108; Schwartz 2006: 9, 12; Ristvet 2012). At the same time, individuals and social structures may have fused with the newly rising powers, contributing to this regeneration. These vestiges might have included low-level administrators, artisans or specialized farmers, who would have provided the foundation for the economic infrastructure of the reestablished social order (Conlee 2003). Movement of individuals and groups was also common; these people, who might have been uprooted from devastated homes or have been seeking new opportunities, thus would have settled within the reascendant society. Together, the various components of the emerging network would seek new paths to expand their capital, including intensification of production, access to new resources and relations with neighboring networks.

Musings on the Arrival of the Philistines

Our knowledge of the Philistines is fragmentary, and largely based on non-Philistine written sources. With the exception of a 7th century BCE royal inscription from Ekron (Gitin, Dothan and Naveh 1997), all the sources at our disposal are Egyptian, Assyrian, Babylonian or biblical. We are therefore relying upon external views.

Gleanings of the early Philistines can be found in the Egyptian sources, embedded in the multi-layered

literary and pictorial language of royal ideology (Redford 2000; Roberts 2009; Ben-Dor Evian 2016). The earliest Philistines probably originated from the Aegean, as attested by their name (Schneider 2012: 570) and their spiky headgear (Yasur-Landau 2013) and would have been equipped with Anatolian and Aegean-style weaponry, Aegean-style boats and Anatolian-style ox-driven carts (Yasur-Landau 2010b; 2012a). Another detail at our disposal is their description as *thr*, a designation for well-trained paid men in the service of the courts of Hatti and Egypt (Ben-Dor Evian 2015). The Philistines can therefore be described as belonging to a transregional phenomenon of vigorous warrior bands with an Aegean and Anatolian background, active throughout the eastern Mediterranean during the final centuries of the second millennium BCE; they either raided coastal regions (Gilan 2013) or fought in their service throughout the Late Bronze Age (e.g., the case of the Sherden; Emanuel 2013: 14–16).

Some of the Philistines were pirates,⁵ as described in the naval battle of Ramesses III, and some were mercenaries, as depicted in additional battle scenes of Ramesses III where warriors with similar headgear are seen fighting in the service of the king. Some of these individuals even became propertied and achieved high social status. The collapse of the palatial system during the late 13th–12th centuries BCE, the turmoil in some parts of the eastern Mediterranean, and the consequent political fragmentation could have been exploited by such bands and their leaders.

The next cluster of evidence comes from memories found in the biblical saga of Saul and David. The stories of the early monarchy had undoubtedly been recounted for generations before being written and rewritten in multiple phases by several generations of scribes; indeed, much ink has been spilled over the reconstruction of its literary history. Both the compilation of this complex text and its interpretation have been shaped by the ideology, personal knowledge and historical

perspective of every scholar involved. As such, the commonly reconstructed narrative which envisions the 11th and 10th centuries BCE as having been dominated by a struggle between the Philistines and the Israelites (among other regional social groups), along with its projection onto the archaeological data, cannot be accepted. There are, however, several elements that provide clues about the historical Philistines, as maintained through memories of the rise of the Israelite monarchy (Koch 2020: 15–22).

A prime anchor for the old memories is the toponymy of the Philistines, or rather, its limited scope. The stories of David preserve the memory of the greatness of Gath during the Iron IIA (Na'aman 1996: 176–178; 2002: 210–212) and the social conditions in the highlands and the Beersheba–Arad Valley prior to the consolidation of Jerusalemite regional hegemony (2 Sam 21:15–22; 23:8–39) (Isser 2003; Na'aman 2010; Finkelstein 2013: 137–149; Sergi 2015: 64–70). There, the Philistines are described as well-trained fierce warriors, led by warlords (*srnym*), raiding villages in the highlands (e.g., 1 Sam 13:17–18) and the lowlands (1 Sam 23:1–5) occupying several strongholds across the highlands (1 Sam 13:3; 2 Sam 23:14) and hiring *'brym*, Hebrews (1 Sam 14:21–22 with LXX), groups of warriors similar to the *'Apiru* mentioned in Late Bronze sources. Naturally, a special place is maintained for the heroic victories of Saul and Jonathan (1 Sam 13–14*), David in the service of Saul (1 Sam 18:14–30*), and David's heroes (2 Sam 21:15–22; 23:9–17).

The conformity between these memories of the Philistine warriors and the image of the *prst* warriors as commemorated by the much earlier Egyptian sources, despite the gap of several centuries, is illuminating, and thus gives rise to new questions about the circumstances that had brought them to the region and that led, in due course, to their hegemony over the local society. In the investigation of this process, the written evidence is of great help. Ultimately, the transformation of the

5. See Hitchcock and Maeir (2014; 2016; 2018) on the Philistines as pirates, although I do not accept the automatic affiliation of the production of monochrome ware with the pirate way of life. The reconstruction of feasting as a primary social practice among pirates—as in other ancient societies, ancient Near Eastern included (Ziffer 2005)—should not automatically lead to the assumption that the production of a specific style of pottery was conducted by the pirate societies themselves.

ethnonym *płst* to a toponym was the principal Philistine legacy.⁶ As fundamental as the naming of the region as Philistia was—a name eventually projected over the entire region—it was not accompanied by additional marked changes in the regional toponymy, which conversely maintained its autochthonous onomasticon for centuries (Shai 2009). Continuity can also be observed in the use of the Canaanite script, as seen in several epigraphic finds from Tell eš-Šafi/Gath and satellite settlements, among them a short inscription dating sometime from the late Iron I to the Early Iron IIA, referring to names with a possible etymology of Anatolian origin (Byrne 2007: 3, 17–23; Davis, Maeir and Hitchcock 2015). The prestigious status of the local dialect is most evident in the latest, longest, and most famous of the epigraphic finds from Philistia: The Ekron royal inscription from the Iron IIC, in which the local name of the city is mentioned alongside the non-local name of the ruler and the local names of his ancestors. Such a process might reflect the arrival(s) of small groups of newcomers who interacted with locals, gradually adopted the local language (and probably

local practices) and eventually bequeathed their own collective identity to the local society at large.

Hypothetically, the Philistines could have arrived when the region was still under Egyptian hegemony or after its collapse. If we opt for the former possibility, they could have served as part of an Egyptian garrison in Gaza and remained after the demise of the empire to become the lords of the new, post-collapse society. A fascinating illumination of such a scenario might be seen decorating a scarab embedded in a gold ring found in an affluent Late Bronze III tomb at Tell el-Far‘ah (S). The scarab depicts a figure similar to the Philistines in the reliefs of Ramesses III receiving a large *‘nh* from Amun-Re in a setting otherwise reserved for royal figures (Keel and Uehlinger 1998: 110). Alternatively, the Philistines might have been involved in the destruction of the post-collapse society during the late Iron I, a chaotic period that concluded with the emergence of Gath as the regional hegemon during the Iron IIA. Any combination of these scenarios is possible as well; the absence of written sources makes it impossible to determine which of these reconstructions is more likely.

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6. Mentioned in Neo-Assyrian sources as early as the days of Adad-nirari III (above), on an Egyptian Third Intermediate Period inscription found on a reused Middle Kingdom statuette that reads “Envoy to the Canaan of Philistines”—dated to the Twenty-Second or even the Twenty-Sixth Dynasty (Redford 1992: 442; Ben-Dor Evian 2011: 98 with earlier literature)—and in a few biblical verses (e.g., Exod 15:14; Isa 14:29,31; Joel 4:4; Pss 60:10).

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